

MORAL AND CITIZENSHIP EDUCATION (MCED 1012)

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The Importance/Goal of Moral and Civic Education

- In higher educational institutions of Ethiopia, civics and ethics/moral education is given with the aim of educating students about: **democratic culture, ethical values and principles, supremacy of constitution, the rule of law, rights and duties of citizens.**
- It helps to produce **self-confident citizens** who **decides on issues based on reason.**

Generally, the necessity of delivering the course emanates from:

1. The need to inculcate citizens about their rights and duties.

2. The Need for Participant Political Culture

- **political culture** is the set of **attitudes, beliefs, and sentiments which give order and meaning to a political process** and which provide the underlying assumptions and rules that govern behavior in the political system.

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- Almond and Verba (1963) construct **three political cultures**: parochial cultures, subject cultures, and participant cultures.
1. In **parochial cultures** citizens have **low cognitive, affective, and evaluative orientation** regarding the political systems, government powers and functions and even their privileges and duties.
 2. In **subject cultures**, there is **high cognitive, affective, and evaluative orientation towards the political system and policy outputs**, but orientations towards input objects (like **political parties**) and the self as active participants are **minimal**.

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3. In **participant cultures**, members of society have **high cognitive, affective, and evaluative orientation to the political system**, the input objects, the policy outputs, and recognize the self as **an active participant in the polity**.
 - Largely, **participant cultures** are most compatible with **democratic political structures** because the **qualities and attitudes of citizens determine the health and stability of a country's democracy**.
3. *The Need for Relevant Knowledge, Skills and Positive Attitudes.*

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4. The issue of fostering intercultural societies.

- *The **recognition of cultural diversity** is certainly meritorious, but civics and ethics education could move a step forward by appealing to the **notion of inter-culturalism**, which explicitly asserts the need for **relationship, dialogue, reciprocity and interdependence**.*

5. The issue of peace-building

- In an environment characterized by increasing **militarization, terrorism, civil wars and genocidal acts**, it is urgent for citizenship education to advance **pedagogical strategies to promote cooperation, dialogue, and a sustainable peace that is based on justice**.

Aristotle says, “**Educating the mind without educating the heart is no education at all.**”

- **Moral and Civics Education** is based on and seeks to promote in students core **moral, ethical, democratic, and educational values**, such as:
 - **Respect for life**
 - **Respect for reasoning**
 - **Fairness**
 - **Concern for the welfare of others**
 - **Respect for diversity**
 - **Peaceful resolution of conflict**

Chapter One: Understanding Civics and Ethics

- **Introduction**
- Human being is a **social animal** and **couldn't live alone**, he/she has to respect **certain fundamental principles and values to live together** with his/her fellow beings and consequently **build peaceful society and lead prosperous life**.
- Aristotle (1955) said that **citizens of a State** should always be educated to suit the **constitution** of a State.
- Accordingly, creating a **good citizen** has been the prior concern of many States, including Ethiopia.
- This is because good citizens are **made not born**.

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- The subject assumed **different names and purposes** depending on countries' **ideologies** and thus the definition of the discipline vary across States.
- Terms such as **Right Education** (in South Africa), **Citizenship Education** (in United States of America and Germany), **Citizenship and Character Education** (in Singapore), **Civics and Ethical Education** (in Ethiopia) are just a few examples that can be found in the literature.

What does civic education mean?

- Civic education is an education that studies about **the rights and responsibilities** of citizens of a **politically organized** group of people.
- Different writers define differently; for example,
- Patrick (1986) defines civic education as **the knowledge of the constitutions, the principles, values, history and application to contemporary life.**
- Citizenship education can be understood as **the knowledge, means, and activities designed** to encourage students to participate actively in **democratic life, accepting and exercising their rights and responsibilities.**

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- United Nations Development Program (UNDP, 2004) defines civic education as a **way of learning for effective participation in a democratic and development process.**
- On his part, Aggarwal (1982) linked civic education to the **development of ideas, habits, behaviors and useful attitudes** in the individual which enables him to be a **useful member of the society.**
- the subject matter can be also defined as the process of helping **young people acquire and learn to use the skills, knowledge, and attitudes** that will prepare them to be **competent and responsible citizens** throughout their lives.

The Definition and Nature of Ethics and Morality

- **What Ethics is?**
- Ethics is a branch of philosophy that attempts to understand people's **moral beliefs and actions**.
- Ethics, or moral philosophy, considers **theories about what human beings are capable of doing**, alongside accounts of **what they ought to do if they are to live an ethically good life**.
- **Ethics** also explores the meaning and the **ranking** of different **ethical values**, such as **honesty, autonomy, equality and justice**, and it considers ethical quandaries that **human beings face in the course of living their own independent but, also, socially interdependent lives**.

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- **Ethics** may share common ground with the **law, religious belief, popular opinion, professional codes and the dictates of authority figures,**
- but it is also broader than all of these and offers a **set of tools and values against which their appropriateness can be evaluated.**
- Ethical questions are not concerned with what one would do (an **essentially psychological concern**) but what **one *ought to do*.**
- **Judgments** about such decisions are generally expressed with words like **right and wrong, should and ought, or obligation and duty.**

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- Occasionally the term **ethics** is used interchangeably with **morals**.
- **Business or medical ethics**, for example, is generally synonymous with **morals**.
- Although this is acceptable, a precise usage would apply the term's **morals and moral to the conduct itself**, while the terms **ethics** and **ethical** would refer to the study of **moral conduct or to the code that one follows**.
- Thus, the specific act of telling the caller you were home could be described as **moral or immoral**.
- But what makes any **act moral or immoral, right or wrong** fall **within the province of ethics**.

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- Thus, “what makes any act, such as **lying or stealing, right or wrong?**” and “what makes any entity good?” are **ethical problems**.
- In short, **morality refers** to the degree to which an **action conforms to a standard or norm of human conduct**.
- Ethics refers to the philosophical study of **values** and of what constitute **good and bad** human conduct.

Generally, Ethics is:

- The critical examination and evaluation of **what is good, evil, right and wrong in human conduct** (Guy, 2001).
- A specific set of **principles, values and guidelines for a particular group or organization** (Guy, 2001).
- Ethics is the study of **goodness, right action and moral responsibility**, it asks what choices and ends we ought to pursue and what moral principles should govern our pursuits and choices (Madden, 2000).

What is Morality?

- Morality, is one of most frequently used terms, it can mean **different things to different people**.
- Morality is a **commonly** used word in **most cultures**.
- Morality from a dictionary definition (from Latin *moralitas* “**manner, character, proper behavior**”) refers to the concept of human action which pertains to matters of **right and wrong** – also referred to as “**good and evil**”.

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- It can be used to mean the generally **accepted code of conduct in a society, or within a subgroup of society.**
- It relates to values expressed as: a matter of **individual choice**, those values to which we ought to **aspire** and those values shared within a **culture, religious**, secular, or philosophical community.
- However, it becomes **ambiguous when defined by different ethnic groups, especially in the multicultural society, like Ethiopians.**

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- Socrates is rightly asserted that morality **is not a small matter.**
- In fact, moral philosophy is the attempt to achieve a **systematic understanding of the nature of morality and what it requires of us.**
- In Socrates' words it's **"how we ought to live".**
- Living in a **multicultural Ethiopia**, how we **ought to live can be very complicated because of the diversity of culture that is vast and unique.**

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- **Ethics** is usually associated with a **certain conduct** within a profession, for example, the code of ethics for the teaching profession.
- **Morality** is a more general term referring to the **character of individuals and community**.

Morality is:

- Those **principles and values** that actually guide, for better or worse, an individual's personal conduct (Guy, 2001)
- The **informal system of rational beings** by which they govern their **behavior in order to lesson harm or evil and do good**, this system, although **informal**, **enjoys amazing agreement across time and cultures concerning moral rules, moral ideas and moral virtues** (Madden, 2000)
- Whatever else may be said about it, is about things over which we have control that lead to “**bettering human life**”.
- It is **different in every society**, and is a **convenient term for socially approved habits**.

Ethics and Law

- As against morals and ethics, **laws are norms**, formally approved by **state, power or national or international** political bodies.
- Many laws are instituted in order to promote well-being, resolve conflicts of interest, and promote social harmony. However, there are several reasons why ethics is not law.
- First, some actions that are **illegal may not be unethical**.
- Speeding is **illegal**, but one might have an **ethical obligation** to break the **speed limit** in order to transport someone to a **hospital in an emergency**.